

The Age of Industrialisation

Social Science — History • Chapter 4 • Chapter Summary & Study Guide for Daksh

Around 1900, an advertisement in a British magazine showed a 'magical' machine spinning thread by itself — the new industrial age was being celebrated everywhere. But this celebration hides a more complicated story. This chapter traces how industrialisation actually unfolded — not as a sudden 'revolution' but a long, uneven transition — in Britain and in colonial India, and the lives of workers it shaped.

Before the factory: Proto-industrialisation

Even before factories, large-scale production was happening — not in factories but in countryside. Merchants in towns supplied yarn and orders; rural peasant families spun and wove cloth at home. This system is called **proto-industrialisation**. It was a vital supplement to family income from farming.

The first factories — and persistence of hand labour

Richard Arkwright's first cotton mill (1771) in England brought all stages of production under one roof. But factories did not eliminate hand labour overnight. Even by the late 19th century:

- Many British industries were not big consumers of new technology.
- Steam engines were slow to spread; only ~80,000 in operation in Britain by 1851.
- Hand-made goods symbolised refinement and class — Victorians valued them.
- Seasonal industries (gas works, breweries, ship-building, road repair) needed flexible, casual hand labour.

Workers, fearing being replaced by machines, sometimes attacked them — the **Spinning Jenny** riots are an example.

Industrialisation in colonial India

India had a flourishing handloom and craft sector before the British. **Surat, Masulipatnam, Hooghly** were thriving export ports. The **East India Company** changed the rules:

- Eliminated competing merchants; established direct control over weavers via **gomasthas** (paid servants).
- Forced weavers into long-term contracts at low prices; weavers could not sell to anyone else; debts and loss of independence followed.
- Indian textiles increasingly displaced from world markets by British cotton goods.

Manchester became the chief supplier — flooding India with cheap mill cloth. Indian weavers suffered huge unemployment. By 1850s, Indian raw cotton was being exported to Britain and finished cloth being imported back.

Indian factories take off

First Indian-owned cotton mills came up in **Bombay (1854)**, then Ahmedabad, Kanpur. Jute mills in Bengal (Rishra, 1855).

- Early entrepreneurs: **Dwarkanath Tagore** in Bengal; **Dinshaw Petit, Jamsetjee Tata** in Bombay; **Seth Hukumchand** set up first Indian jute mill in 1917.
- Indian capital came from China-trade profits, banking, railway construction.
- The **jobber** — a foreman/recruiter — controlled hiring, demanding gifts and favours from workers.
- Indian factories employed mostly migrant labour from UP, Bihar, Maharashtra; women's share was low.

WWI and the Indian industrial spurt

World War I (1914-18) gave Indian industries a sudden boost: Britain stopped exporting cloth to India (needed it for the war), and demanded military supplies — uniforms, tents, ammunition boxes — from Indian factories. Capital and output swelled. After the war, Manchester never recovered its Indian market; Indian textile industry consolidated.

Small industries continued to survive

The handloom did not die; it adapted. By the 1940s, handloom production had nearly doubled.

- Borders, special weaves (Banarasi, Madras handkerchiefs), fine cottons of Bengal — these had no factory substitute.
- Weavers adopted small technologies: fly shuttle, dyes, finer yarn.
- Working long hours, often as a family enterprise, kept costs low.

Markets for goods — the role of advertisements

Producing goods is one thing — making people *buy* them is another. Advertisements shaped a new mass market:

- British Manchester cloth labels carried images of Indian gods (Krishna, Saraswati) to make them feel familiar.
- Calendars with images, distributed free, helped products reach those who couldn't read newspapers.
- Indian manufacturers used nationalist symbols — Bharat Mata, freedom fighters — connecting buying their goods with patriotism.

★ MUST-REMEMBER POINTS

- Proto-industrialisation = pre-factory rural production for distant markets, organised by town merchants.
- First cotton mill: Arkwright (1771); first Indian cotton mill: Bombay 1854; first Indian jute mill: Rishra 1855.
- Gomasthas — Company-paid servants who supervised and forced weavers into low-price contracts.
- Manchester flooded India with cheap cloth → ruined Indian handloom weavers.
- WWI gave Indian factories a major boost; killed Manchester's Indian market.
- Jobbers controlled factory recruitment; took bribes from workers.
- Advertisements with Indian gods and nationalist images shaped Indian consumers.

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